

Why it's important

Some people argue that internet access is now a human right. In many countries, the internet plays an essential role in daily business and education. Restricting access would harm the poorest segments of the population the most. Net neutrality also plays a role in promoting free speech, encouraging competition, protecting privacy, and exposing corruption.



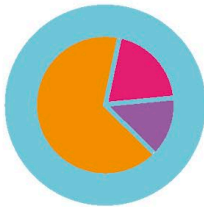
Minority groups

Social, ethnic, and religious minorities use the web to coordinate events and fight oppression within their country. Giving a government or an ISP the ability to stop their capacity to communicate effectively is essentially another form of oppression.



Freedom of speech

Net neutrality prevents companies, organizations, or governments from censoring opinions they don't like. Some governments around the world have already done away with net neutrality, to the detriment of their citizens' personal freedom.



Businesses

Without net neutrality, the internet would favour big, established businesses with lots of money, and make it harder for startups and entrepreneurs to gain a significant presence.

IN DEPTH

The counter-argument

In 2014, the US ISP Comcast deliberately slowed the US entertainment site Netflix data and forced the company to pay huge sums of money to fix it. Comcast argued that the bandwidth required for Netflix movies was a massive drain on resources. In other words, everyone's internet was slower because so many people streamed content from Netflix. Getting rid of net neutrality would force resource-intensive content, such as Netflix, to pay for better infrastructure. It might also encourage ISPs to spread out into more rural areas. The internet would be treated like regular commodities that respond to the market forces of supply and demand.

Net neutrality around the world

Since the early 2000s, countries around the world have been passing digital laws and trying to figure out how to regulate the internet. Different places have different answers for questions, such as who should monitor content, who is responsible for cybercrime, and whether the internet is owned by governments, ISPs, or people.

India: in favour of net neutrality

In 2016, the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) banned Facebook's Free Basics program on the grounds that it violated net neutrality. Free Basics allows users to access certain websites, chosen by Facebook, for free.

The United States: repealing net neutrality

In late 2017, the US government indicated it wanted to repeal net neutrality rules, but sought to allay the fears of pro-net neutrality advocates by promising to deal with companies who exploit users.

Portugal: partial net neutrality

The Portuguese telecommunications company MEO offers users different packages of internet access. For example, a user can pay for a messaging service only, and pay more for video-streaming or social media access.

Morocco: no net neutrality

The government has the right to block content that threatens the Moroccan monarchy, the Islamic faith, or public order. Transgressors face heavy fines or prison sentences. After recent crackdowns on online journalists, there is speculation about violations of human rights.

REAL WORLD

The Golden Shield Project

Nicknamed the Great Firewall of China, the Golden Shield Project is the Chinese government's project to restrict access to websites in the name of state security. Banned websites include Google, Facebook, and *The New York Times*. More than 2 million internet police constantly monitor data being sent or received. State-approved Chinese companies such as the microblogging website Sina Weibo offer alternatives to the banned sites.